Russia, to intrigue against Britain in Persia.[113] As Cox himself noted, it 'seems quixotic that we should be giving so much help to Denikin, and should have maintained [the] division itself for so long, and now allow them to remain a serious menace to successful progress of our policy'.[114] For whatever reason, Curzon had apparently failed to appreciate the risk that lay in providing financial support to an armed Russian contingent in Persia while simultaneously trying to undermine the basis of that force. He had failed to predict just how far the agreement would antagonise the Russian Whites and had arguably made Britain's position in Persia less secure by it. In effect, the Great Game thinking that had informed his actions in this period re-awakened many of the Great Game tensions that had lain dormant for the past five years.

The Wasps' Nest

While the Indian government struggled to have its authority taken seriously in London in relation to Persia, when it came to Afghanistan things should have been more clear cut. Not only was Afghanistan inextricably linked to India via proximity, religion and its connections with the tribes on India's North-West Frontier, since 1880, with the conclusion of the Second Afghan War, the Government of India had had control of Afghanistan's external relations.[115] Nevertheless, this did not prevent the Home government from interfering when it could. In June 1918, for example, in a meeting of the Eastern Committee, Chief of Imperial General Staff (CIGS) Sir Henry Wilson questioned the Indian government's judgement over Afghanistan. Wilson advocated persuading emir Habibullah to join the conflict, arguing that, with the collapse of Russia, Afghanistan had become extremely vulnerable to penetration by the Central Powers.[116] He accused the Indian government of being 'diffident about formulating any definite course of action' in regard to Afghanistan, and pushed for the War Cabinet to take control of policy towards that country.[117] Curzon too was keen to make Afghanistan a formal ally, believing that together with Persia it could form 'a Moslem nexus of states' which would stop a German and Turkish advance into Asia. Yet again, Curzon also tried to exert his authority over India, pointing out during the meeting that 'the Viceroy of India and his